

Personal Statement — CCCW Postdoctoral Fellowship (Ref. 535079)

University of Hong Kong

Mengnan Xu

The governance of complex societies demands both rigorous theoretical frameworks and sophisticated analytical tools. My research sits at precisely this intersection: trained as a political scientist and public management scholar at Beijing Normal University, I have spent eight years studying how the Chinese state builds governance capacity through multi-actor coordination — and the past year learning, from the inside, how artificial intelligence reshapes the tools available for that inquiry. It is this combination — empirical grounding in public policy, social governance and production-level AI engineering practice — that I bring to the Postdoctoral Fellowship at the Centre on Contemporary China and the World.

My doctoral dissertation (Beijing Normal University, 2018–2026) examines the organizational ecology of China’s poverty alleviation governance and the formation of what I call a “development governance knowledge system” — a distinctive model of state-led multi-actor coordination that departs fundamentally from the NGO-driven, donor-dependent frameworks dominant in mainstream international development research. The central argument is that China’s anti-poverty capacity rests not on hierarchical state command alone, but on a structured mobilization system that integrates government agencies, universities, enterprises, financial institutions, and social organizations into a coherent, large-scale governance architecture with deep grassroots embeddedness. Analyzing this organizational ecosystem required building a structured database of participating actors across time, space, and function — a methodological undertaking that ultimately shaped my engagement with computational tools.

Two publications directly reflect this research program. My first-authored paper, “Poor and Lazy: Understanding Middle-class Perceptions of Poverty in China” (Journal of Contemporary China, 2022, SSCI Q1), examines the ideational environment in which poverty governance operates, showing how dominant middle-class stigmatization of the poor as morally deficient creates the attitudinal context that makes state-organized, non-market-mediated redistribution politically necessary and institutionally distinctive. Additional collaborative work on tobacco control policy evaluation in China (BMJ Open, 2019; Health, 2019) further developed my competency in quantitative policy analysis using longitudinal administrative data.

Yet I encountered a genuine methodological ceiling. Systematically mapping China’s poverty governance organizational ecosystem at national scale — tracking which actors participated, in which counties, through which institutional channels, over a two-decade period — requires processing hundreds of thousands of policy documents, government reports, and organizational records. Conventional methods simply cannot do this at the required scope. I made a deliberate

choice: to acquire, from the inside, the computational infrastructure to do this work properly.

Between June 2025 and March 2026, I worked as a software engineer on Apple's Intelligence platform — the system underlying Apple's AI integration across its product ecosystem. This was methodological training at the frontier. Working on production-scale natural language processing pipelines, retrieval-augmented generation architectures, and large-scale knowledge integration systems gave me an engineer's understanding of how LLMs process, organize, and extract structured information from massive document corpora. Crucially, I learned not only how to deploy these tools as a researcher, but how they work — and therefore where they are reliable and where they introduce systematic distortions that require scholarly correction. Since April 2026, I have continued building this technical foundation at AOI, designing full-pipeline automated data collection and analysis systems, deepening my competence in large-scale data ingestion, cleaning, and multi-dimensional statistical analysis.

The research agenda I bring to CCCW directly applies these capabilities to the governance questions I have spent eight years developing. I propose two connected projects. The first is the computational completion of my dissertation's core empirical contribution: using LLM-powered document analysis to construct a comprehensive organizational ecology database of China's poverty alleviation governance, enabling systematic analysis of actor participation structures, the logic of cross-sector coordination, and the spatial and temporal evolution of the state's mobilization architecture. This project contributes to CCCW's agenda on Chinese political leadership and governance while demonstrating a replicable methodology for AI-assisted analysis of party-state governance at scale.

The second project extends this framework internationally. China's development governance knowledge system — its distinctive combination of state capacity, organizational mobilization, and grassroots embeddedness — is not contained within China's borders. Through Belt and Road Initiative channels and South-South cooperation frameworks, these governance models are increasingly present in ASEAN countries and across the Global South. Tracing the institutional diffusion of China's development governance knowledge, and analyzing how it interacts with existing local governance structures in recipient countries, bridges CCCW's priorities on Chinese governance, AI methods for social science, and regional studies of ASEAN.

CCCW represents an ideal environment for this work. The Centre's explicit investment in AI methods for social science research, its commitment to rigorous interdisciplinary scholarship on contemporary China, and its position at the nexus of mainland Chinese and international academic networks make it uniquely suited to support the kind of methodological and thematic bridge-building I aim to do. Hong Kong's distinctive intellectual ecology — embedded in yet analytically distanced from the mainland — provides precisely the institutional vantage point from which to study Chinese governance with both depth and critical rigor.

I look forward to the possibility of contributing to and learning from the Centre's scholarly community.